

Syntax

*Introduction to linguistics – **Course Website** – 17 & 24 November 2025*

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Outline

Syntax and grammar

Sentence grammar

- “Syntax is concerned with the way in which words combine to form larger units such as sentences.
- Although texts or utterances often consist of more than one sentence, it makes sense, for certain purposes of analysis at least, to consider the sentence the largest unit of description.”

(Herbst 2010: 142)

Syntactic hierarchy

- sentence
 - clauses
 - ↪ phrases
 - ↪ words
 - ↪ morphemes

Exercise: splitting into sentences, clauses, phrases, and words

Divide the following into sentences, clauses, phrases, and words:

I gave them some money because they needed it.

sentences

I gave them some money because they needed it.

clauses

I gave them some money

because they needed it

phrases

I

gave

them

some money

because

they

needed

it

words

I

gave

them

some

money

because

they

needed

it

Clauses and sentences

Herbst (2010): 143–144; citing Quirk et al. (1985): 2.11

“[...] the **clause** is a much more clearly definable unit of linguistic analysis than the sentence.

- A clause can occur as a **dependent** (or **subordinate**) clause if it forms a constituent of a larger clause as in
→ (2)_{PW} *Barbara Hepworth had also begun to work in metal.*
- an **independent** clause if it is not a constituent of a larger clause as in
→ (3)_{PH} *We shall now watch New York as eagerly as Paris for new developments.*

The term sentence will be used

- for a **single independent clause** that is not co-ordinated with another clause as in (3)
- for a **combination of two or more independent clauses** in co-ordination as in
→ (4)_{PH} *It was an October night and a full moon was rising over Godrevy.*

Exercise: identifying clauses

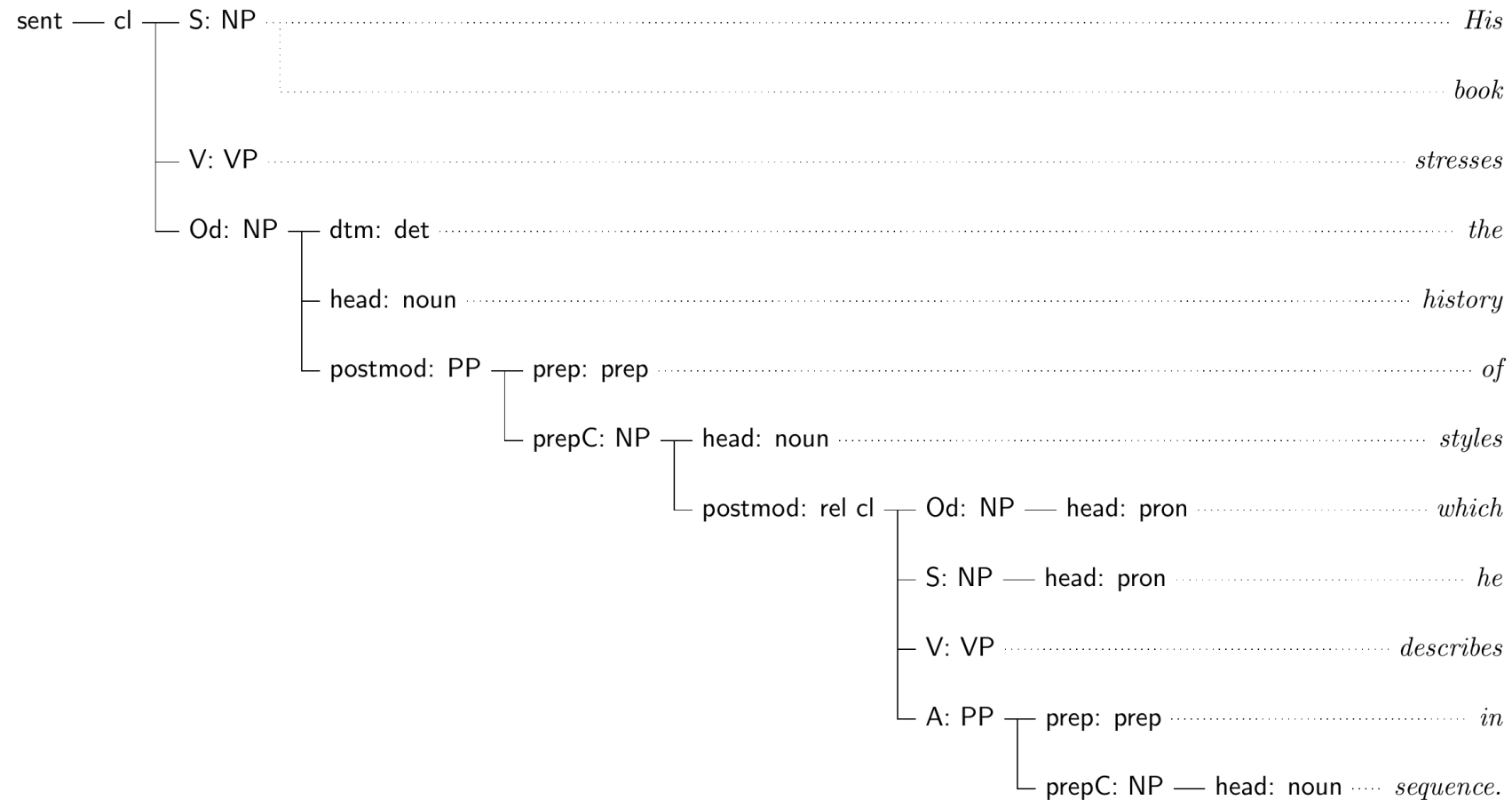
Identify all dependent/subordinate and independent/main clauses in the following sentences:

1. *The cats have been asleep for days.*
2. *I admire their reasoning and I accept their conclusions.*
3. *Although I admire their reasoning, I reject their conclusions.*
4. *Playing the piano is great and I want to be brilliant at it.*
5. *His book stresses the history of styles, which he describes in sequence.*

1. *[The cats have been asleep for days.]^{cl_main}*
2. *[I admire their reasoning]^{cl_main} and [I accept their conclusions]^{cl_main}.*
3. *[[Although I admire their reasoning]^{cl_sub}, I reject their conclusions]^{cl_main}.*
4. *[Playing the piano is great]^{cl_main} and [I want to be brilliant at it]^{cl_main}.*
5. *[His book stresses the history of styles, [which he describes in sequence]^{cl_sub}]^{cl_main}.*

Example: full syntactic analysis

His book stresses the history of styles, which he describes in sequence.



Exercise: identifying finite and non-finite subordinate clauses

Indicate if the subordinate clauses in the following sentences are finite or non-finite:

1. *Playing the piano is great.*
2. *That we need a new banking settlement is clear.*
3. *Do you want to know whether I'm 'anti' or 'pro'?*
4. *All they wanted was to see them one last time.*

1. *[Playing the piano]^{cl_sub_nonfin} is great.*
2. *[That we need a new banking settlement]^{cl_sub_nonfin} is clear.*
3. *Do you want to know [whether I'm 'anti' or 'pro']^{cl_sub_fin}?*
4. *[All they wanted]^{cl_sub_fin} was [to see them one last time]^{cl_sub_nonfin}.*

The elements of clause structure

Subject, predicate, adjunct

(6) _{PH}	<i>We</i>	<i>were</i>	<i>actually</i>	<i>in St. Ives</i>	<i>when I painted them</i>
	SUBJECT	PREDICATE →I	ADJUNCT 1	PREDICATE I←	ADJUNCT 2

(2) _{PW}	<i>Barbara Hepworth</i>	<i>had</i>	<i>also</i>	<i>begun to work in metal</i>
	SUBJECT	PREDICATE→I	ADJUNCT	I← PREDICATE

(7) _{TS}	<i>Following Ben Nicholson's first visit to St. Ives</i>	<i>he</i>	<i>painted a number of landscapes and sea paintings of Porthmeor beach.</i>
	ADJUNCT	SUBJECT	PREDICATE

Objects and complements

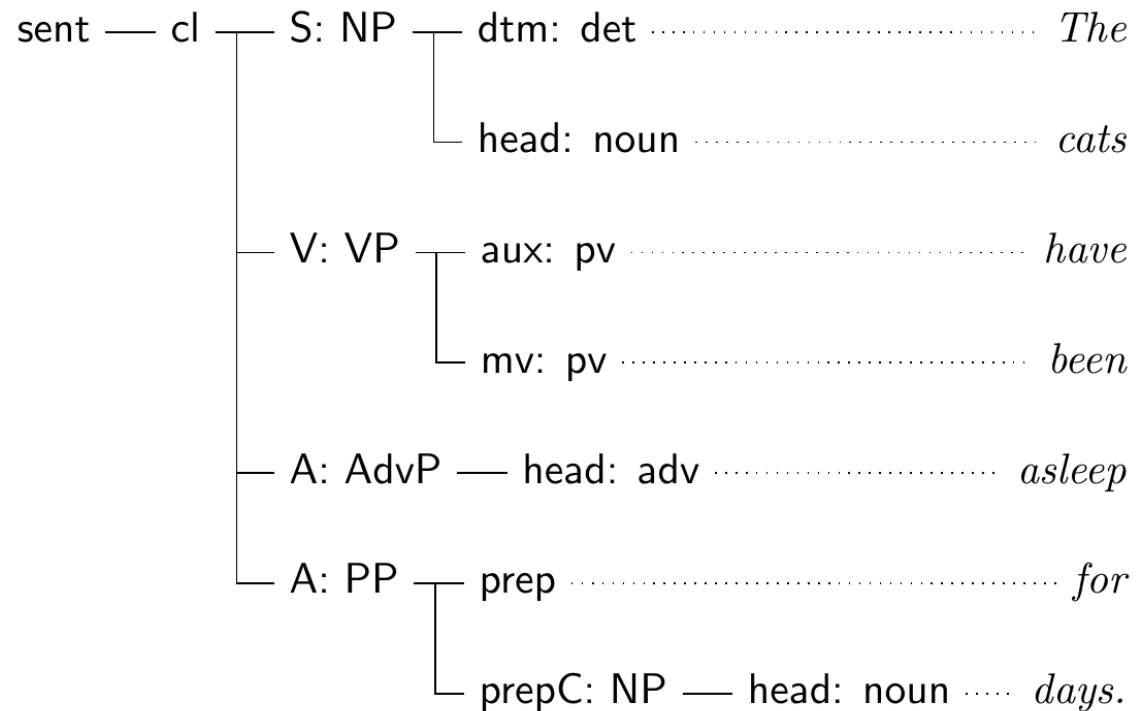
(Herbst 2010: 149)

“The distinction between objects and complements is made on the basis of two main criteria:

- objects can become the subjects of **passive** clauses, complements cannot
- complements refer in some way to the **subject** or **object** of the clause (hence the distinction between subject complements and object complements), objects do not.”

Form and function

The cats have been asleep for days.



Exercise; identifying the elements of clause structure

Identify the elements of clause structure in the following sentences.

1. *The driver gave them a free ride.*
2. *They have been reading for a while.*
3. *I might be here again next month.*
4. *Kevin is very afraid of dogs.*
5. *Some people consider them the best band on earth.*
6. *Honestly, I did see him briefly in the park yesterday when he was feeding the ducks.*

1. The driver^{S:NP} gave^{V:VP} them^{O_i:NP} a free ride^{O_d:NP}.
2. They^{S:NP} have been reading^{V:VP} for a while^{A:AdvP}.
3. I^{S:NP} might be^{V:VP} here^{A:AdvP} again^{A:AdvP} next month^{A:NP}.
4. Kevin^{S:NP} is^{V:VP} very afraid of dogs^{Cs:AdjP}.
5. Some people^{S:NP} consider^{V:VP} them^{O_i:NP} the best band on earth^{O_d:NP}.
6. Honestly^{A:Adv}, I^{S:NP} did see^{V:VP} him^{O_d:NP} briefly^{A:Adv} in the park^{A:AdvP} yesterday^{A:AdvP} when he was feeding the ducks^{A:cl_sub_fin}.

Clause types

clause type		verb class (CGEL)	valency (> 12.3)
SV	<i>She is reading</i>	intransitive	1
SVC	<i>This is an island</i>	copula	2
SVA	<i>She was there</i>	copula	2
SVO	<i>She is reading a book</i>	monotransitive	2
SVOO	<i>He gave her the book</i>	ditransitive	3
SVOC	<i>She called him a fool</i>	complex transitive	3
SVOA	<i>She put the book on the table</i>	complex transitive	3

Herbst (2010): 151

Exercise: matching clause types

Match the following sentences with the correct clause type (CGEL):

- | | |
|---|------------------------------------|
| 1. <i>She – was reading.</i> | a. SV |
| 2. <i>We – were – too early.</i> | b. SVO _d |
| 3. <i>We – sent – them – a parcel.</i> | c. SVO _i O _d |
| 4. <i>He – became – the President of the United States.</i> | d. SVC _s |
| 5. <i>I – read – a book.</i> | e. SVA |
| 6. <i>I – put – the book – on the shelf.</i> | f. SVO _d C _o |
| 7. <i>We – find – clause patterns – fascinating.</i> | g. SVO _d A |

1. *She – was reading.*: **SV**
2. *We – were – too early.*: **SVC_s**
3. *We – sent – them – a parcel.*: **SVO_iO_d**
4. *He – became – the President of the United States.*: **SVC_s**
5. *I – read – a book.*: **SVO_d**
6. *I – put – the book – on the shelf.*: **SVO_dA**
7. *We – find – clause patterns – fascinating.*: **SVO_dO_d**

Exercise: identifying dependent/subordinate clauses

Underline all dependent/subordinate clauses in the sentences below and determine their syntactic function.

1. *That cities will attract more and more criminals is a safe prediction.*
2. *This shows how difficult the question must have been.*
3. *Being a farmer, he is suspicious of all governmental interference.*
4. *We knew that he was a lousy driver.*
5. *The problem is who will water my plants when I am away.*
6. *No further discussion arising, the meeting was brought to a close.*

1. *[That cities will attract more and more criminals]^{cl_sub_fin} is a safe prediction.*
2. *This shows [how difficult the question must have been]^{cl_sub_fin}.*
3. *[Being a farmer]^{cl_sub_nonfin}, he is suspicious of all governmental interference.*
4. *We knew [that he was a lousy driver]^{cl_sub_fin}.*
5. *The problem is [who will water my plants when I am away]^{cl_sub_fin}.*
6. *[No further discussion arising]^{cl_sub_nonfin}, the meeting was brought to a close.*

Phrases

Noun phrases

determinative	premodifier	head: noun or pronoun	postmodifier
<i>the</i>		<i>town</i>	<i>of St Ives</i>
<i>many</i>	<i>very interesting</i>	<i>paintings</i>	<i>showing St Ives Bay</i>
<i>a</i>	<i>spectacular</i>	<i>view</i>	<i>over the bay</i>
<i>the</i>		<i>one</i>	<i>that I mean</i>
		<i>St Ives</i>	<i>which is an artists' community</i>
		<i>they</i>	
<i>this</i>	<i>fascinating</i>	<i>book</i>	<i>on linguistics</i>

Herbst (2010): 154

Verb phrases

auxiliary verbs	main verb
<i>is</i>	<i>paints</i> <i>painting</i>
<i>has been</i>	<i>painted</i>
<i>may have been</i>	<i>painted</i>

Herbst (2010): 155

Adjective phrases

premodifier	head: adjective	postmodifier
<i>very</i>	<i>beautiful</i>	
	<i>nice</i>	
	<i>friendly</i>	<i>to him</i>
<i>too</i>	<i>far</i>	<i>to walk</i>

Herbst (2010): 156

Adverb phrases

premodifier	head: adverb	postmodifier
<i>very</i> <i>much more</i>	<i>beautifully</i> <i>well</i> <i>slowly</i>	<i>indeed</i> <i>than they had expected</i>

Herbst (2010): 156

Prepositional phrases

preposition	prepositional complement
<i>to</i>	<i>the island</i>
<i>on</i>	<i>going there</i>

Herbst (2010): 156

Exercise: identifying noun phrases

Identify all noun phrases in the following sentences.

1. *The driver gave them a free ride.*
2. *I might be here again next month.*
3. *October arrived, spreading a damp chill over the grounds and into the castle.*
4. *The bassist they had just casted left the next day.*

1. The driver gave them a free ride.
2. I might be here again next month.
3. October arrived, spreading a damp chill over the grounds and into the castle.
4. The bassist they had just casted left the next day.

Exercise: identifying verb phrases

Identify all verb phrases in the following sentences.

1. *The driver gave them a free ride.*
2. *I might be here again next month.*
3. *They have been reading for a while.*
4. *The bassist might have been leaving.*

1. The driver gave them a free ride.
2. I might be here again next month.
3. They have been reading for a while.
4. The bassist might have been leaving.

Exercise: identifying phrase types

Give the term for the formal elements (= phrases) underlined in the following sentences.

1. *I might be here again next month.*
2. *They left in a rush.*
3. *They did amazingly well.*
4. *The man who came here yesterday was his brother.*
5. *Charlie is very anxious about their health.*
6. *She fell in love with the girl in the dark grey dress.*

1. *I might be here (**AdvP**) again (**AdvP**) next month.*
2. *They left in a rush (**AdvP**).*
3. *They did amazingly well (**AdvP**).*
4. *The man who came here yesterday (**NP**) was his brother.*
5. *Charlie is very anxious about their health (**AdjP**).*
6. *She fell in love with the girl in the dark grey dress (**NP**).*

Word classes

Overview

I	NOUN	<i>John, room, answer, play</i> (> 11.4.1)
II	ADJECTIVE	<i>happy, steady, new, large, round</i> (> 11.4.4)
III	FULL VERB	<i>search, grow, play</i> (> 11.4.3)
IV	ADVERB	<i>steadily, completely, really</i>
V	PREPOSITION	<i>of, at, in, without, in spite of</i> (> 11.4.7)
VI	PRONOUN	<i>he, they, anybody, one, which</i> (> 11.4.6)
VII	DETERMINER	<i>the, a, that, every, some</i> (> 11.4.6.)
VIII	CONJUNCTION	<i>and, that, when, although</i> (> 11.4.7)
IX	MODAL VERB	<i>can, must, will, would</i> (>11.4.3)
X	PRIMARY VERB	<i>be, have, do</i> (> 11.4.3)
XI	NUMERAL	<i>one, two, three; first, second, third</i>
XII	INTERJECTION	<i>oh, ah, ugh, phew</i>
words of unique function		<i>not</i> (negative particle), <i>to</i> (infinitive marker)

Herbst (2010): 160; based on Quirk et al. (1985): 2.34

Exercise: determining word classes

Determine the word class of all the words in the following sentences taken from Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets.

October arrived, spreading a damp chill over the grounds and into the castle.

Madam Pomfrey, the nurse, was kept busy by a sudden spate of colds among the staff and students. Her [...] potion worked instantly, though it left the drinker smoking at the ears for several hours afterward.

October^{n_prop} arrived^{v_full}, spreading^{v_full} a^{det} damp^{adj} chillⁿ over^{prep} the^{det} groundsⁿ and^{conj} into^{prep} the^{det} castleⁿ. Madam Pomfrey^{n_prop}, the nurseⁿ, was^{v_prim} kept^{v_full} busy^{adj} by^{prep} a^{det} sudden^{adj} spateⁿ of^{prep} coldsⁿ among^{prep} the^{det} staffⁿ and^{conj} studentsⁿ. Her^{det} [...] potionⁿ worked^{v_full} instantly^{adv}, though^{conj} it^{pron_pers} left^{v_full} the drinkerⁿ smoking^{v_full} at^{prep} the^{det} earsⁿ for^{prep} several^{det} hoursⁿ afterward^{adv}.

Verbs

Verbal inflection

base form	<i>paint, put, speak, write</i>	
{S}-form	<i>paints, puts, speaks, writes</i>	finite
past tense form	<i>painted, put, spoke, wrote</i>	finite
-ing-participle/present part.	<i>painting, putting, speaking, writing</i>	non-finite
-ed-participle/past participle	<i>painted, put, spoken, written</i>	non-finite

Herbst (2010): 161

Modal and primary verbs

It seems appropriate to distinguish two further types of verb from the class of lexical (or full) verbs (CGEL 3.21), namely

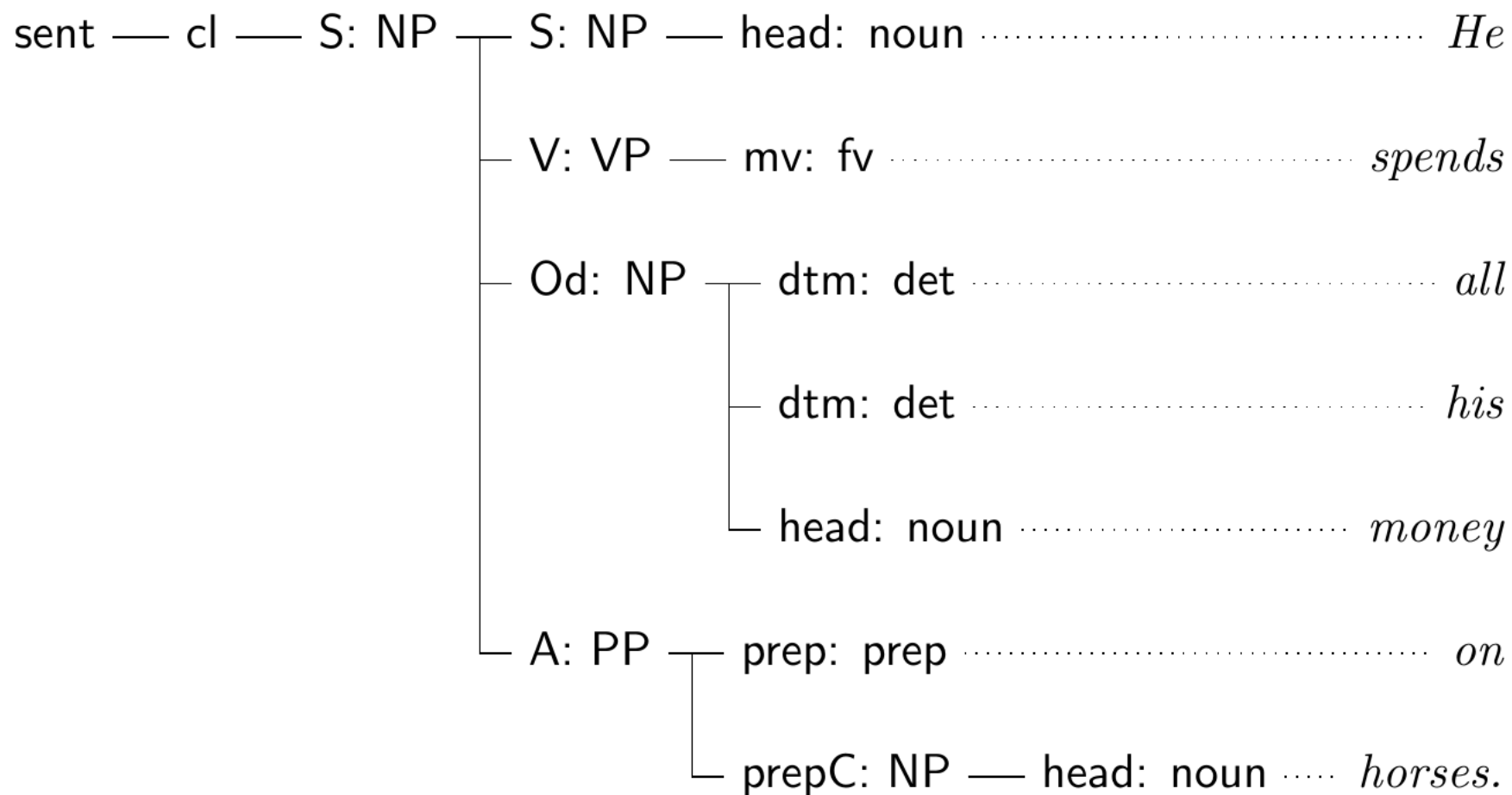
- ▷ **modal verbs** (*can, may, shall, will, could, might, should, would* and *must*), which are characterized by the fact that they do not admit suffixation by {S} and do not have participle forms, and
- ▷ the **primary verbs** *be* (which, by the way, has eight different morphological forms), *do* and *have*, which can occur as auxiliaries or main verbs in the verb phrase.

Herbst (2010): 162

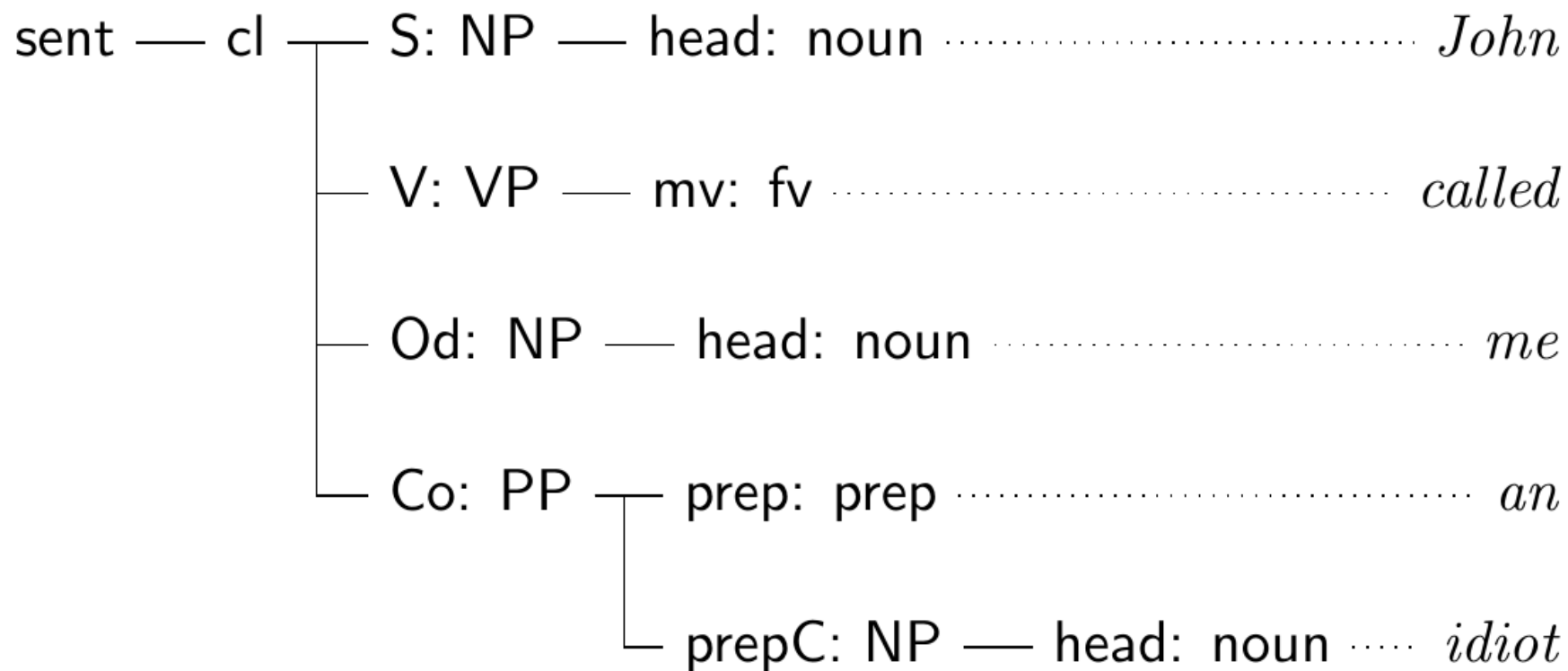
Full syntactic analysis

Give a full syntactic analysis of the following sentences.

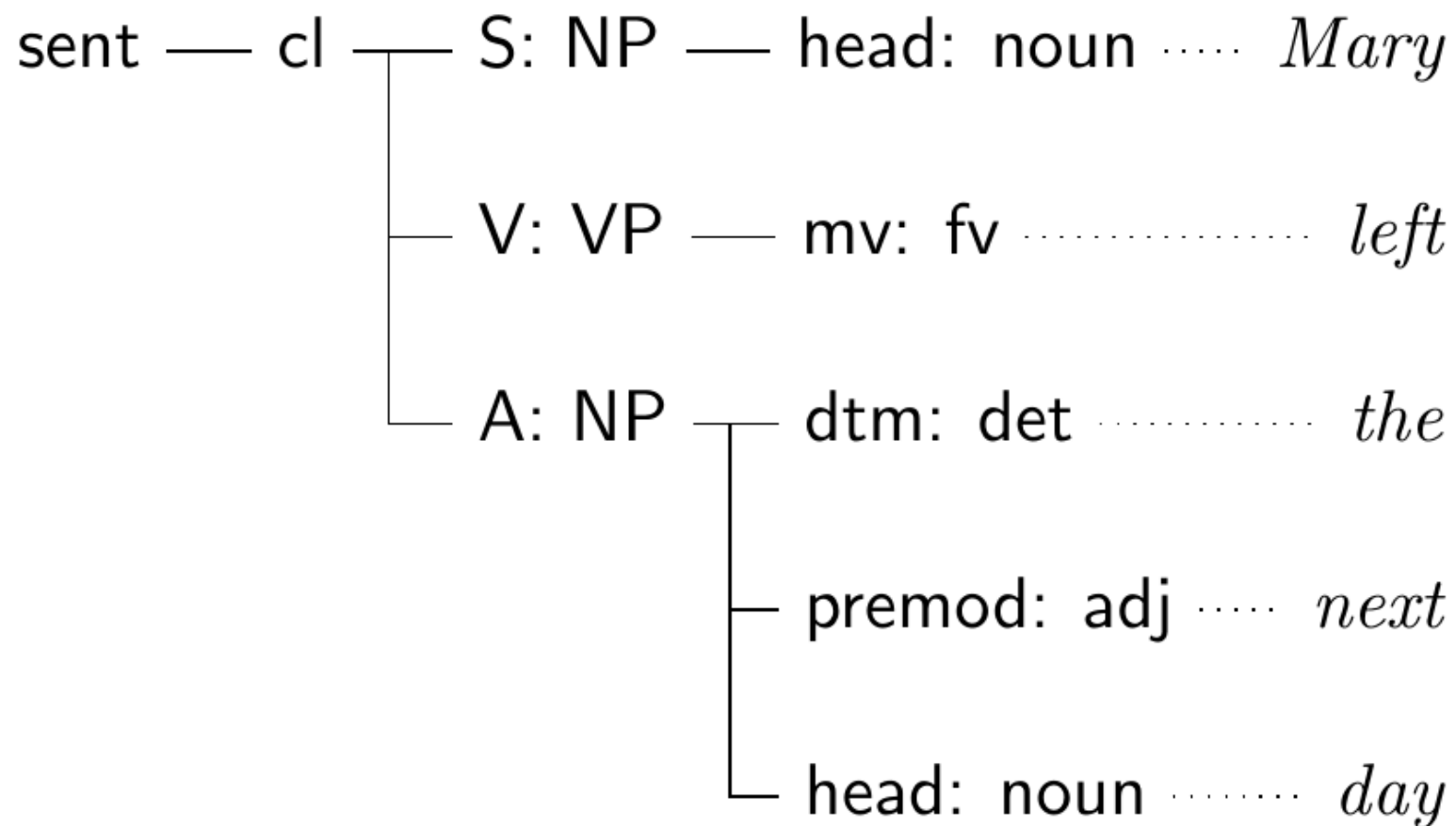
He spends all his money on horses.



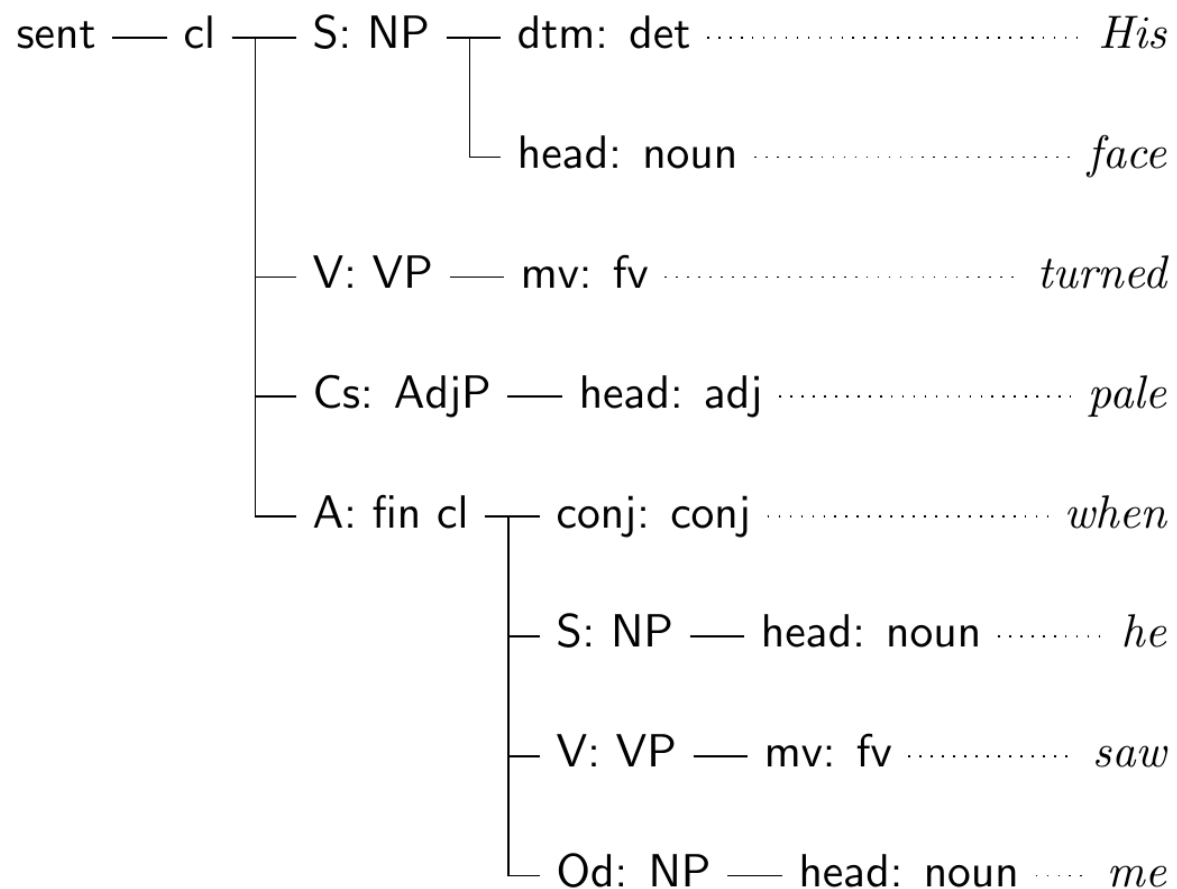
John called me an idiot.



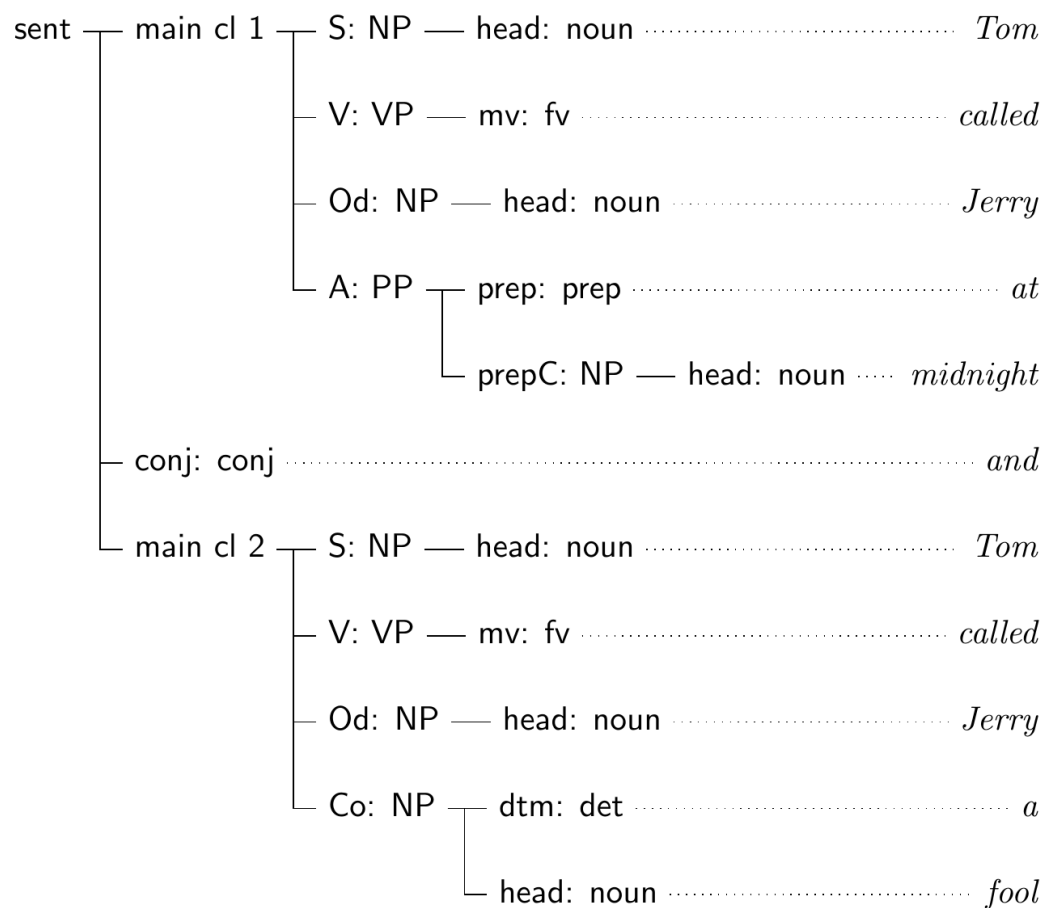
Mary left the next day.



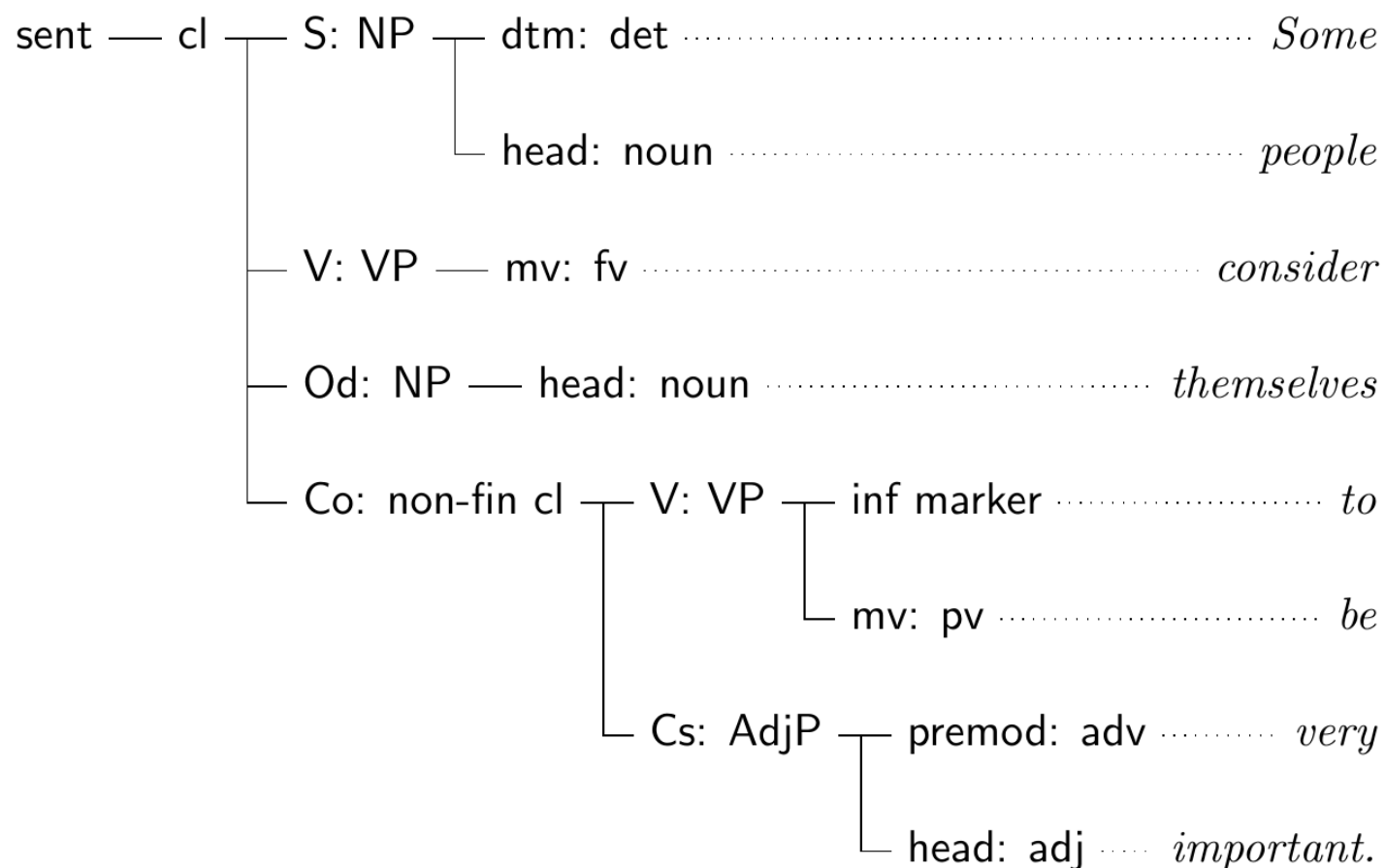
His face turned pale when he saw me.



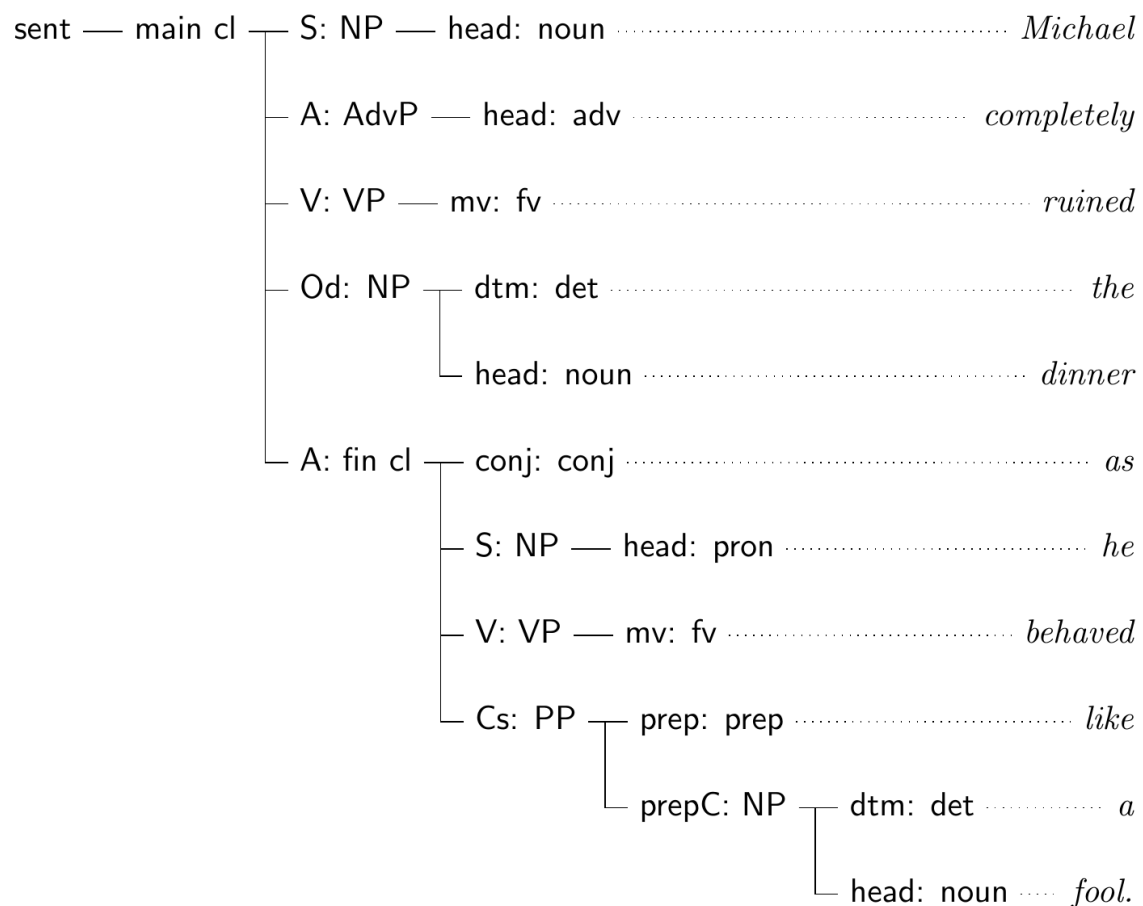
Tom called Jerry at midnight and Tom called Jerry a fool.



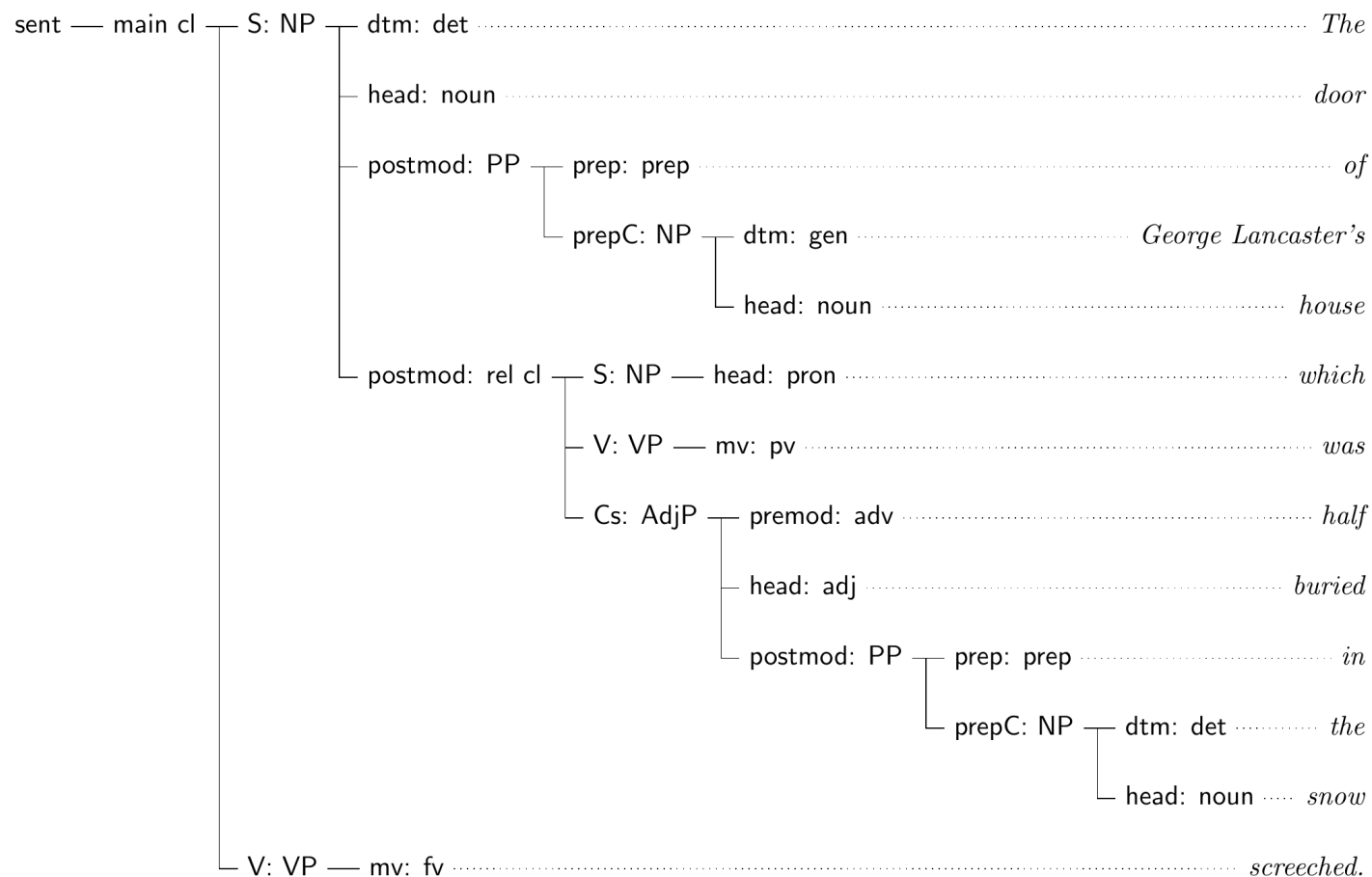
Some people consider themselves to be very important.



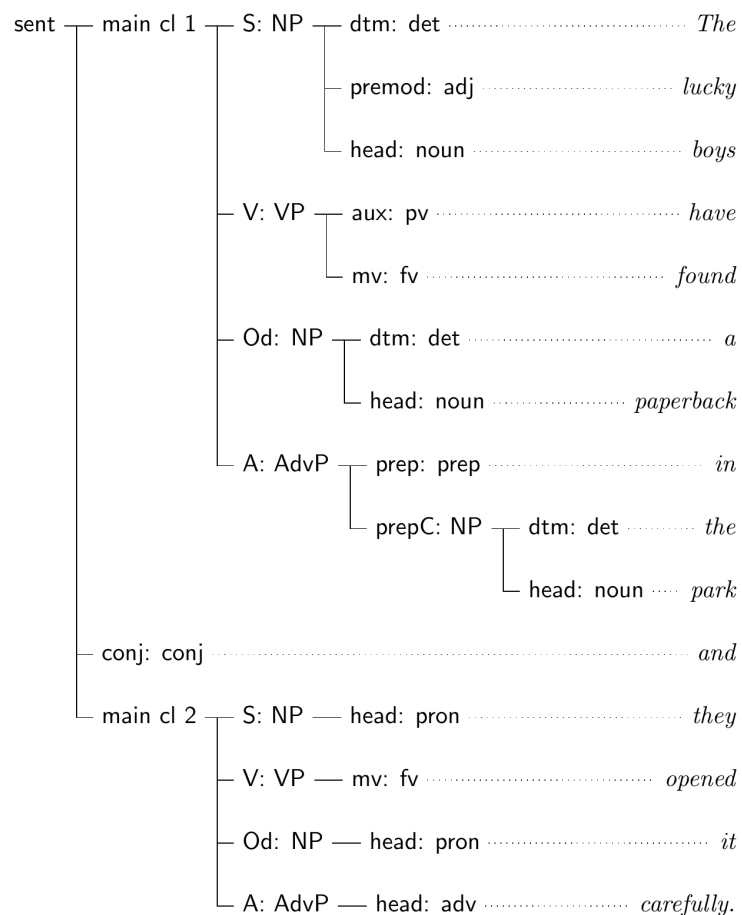
Michael completely ruined the dinner as he behaved like a fool.



The door of George Lancaster's house, which was half buried in the snow, screeched.



The lucky boys have found a paperback in the park and they opened it carefully.

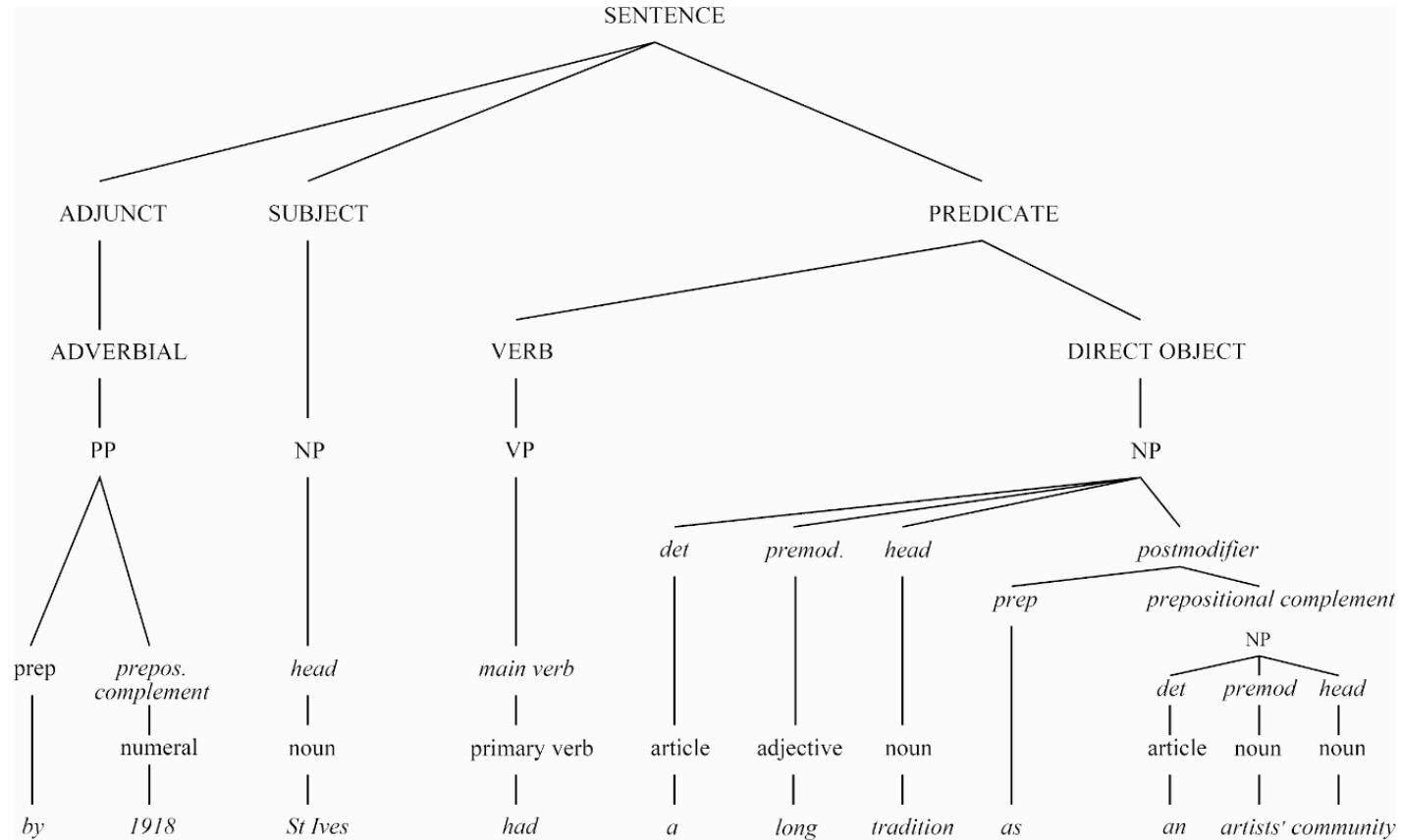


Valency theory and case grammar

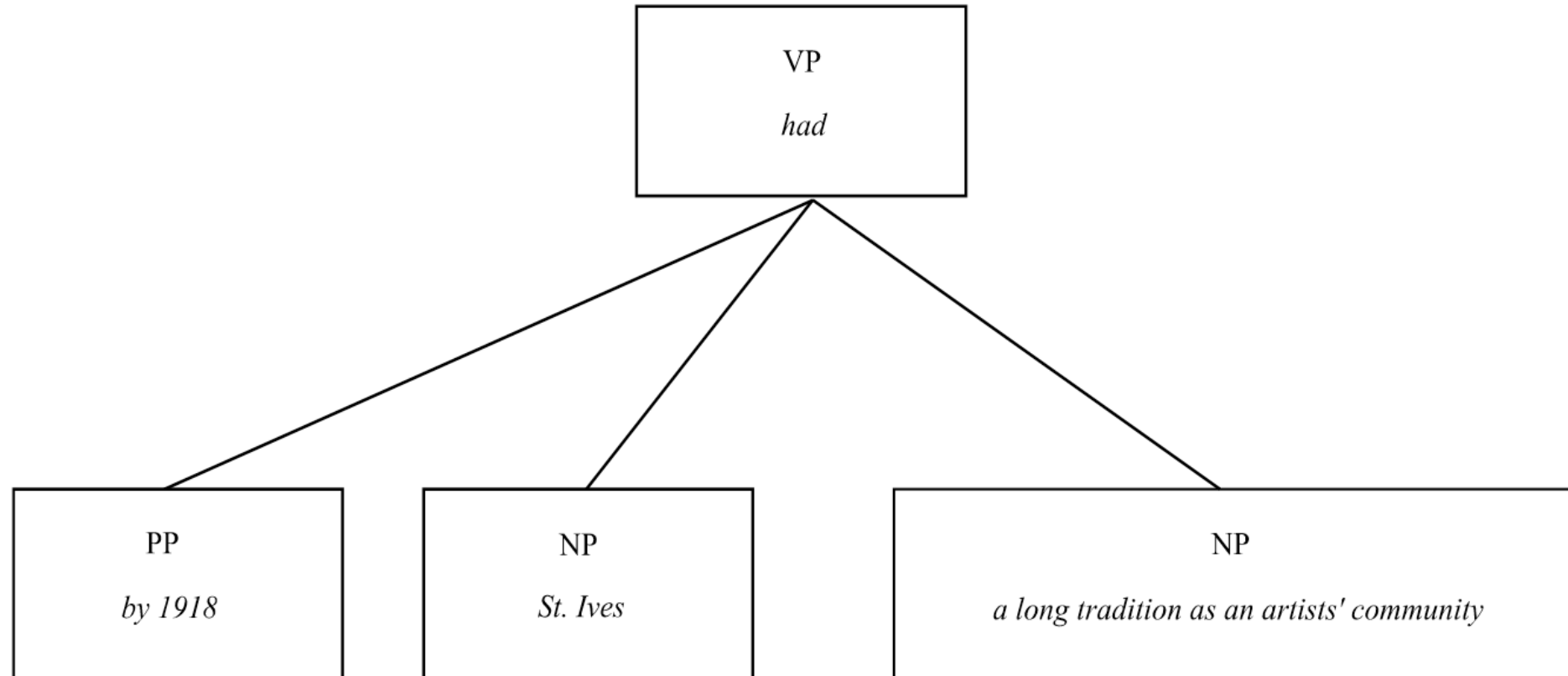
Constituency grammar

By 1918 St Ives had a long tradition as an artists' community.

Herbst (2010): 171



Dependency grammar



Herbst (2010): 175

Case grammar and participant roles

Herbst (2010): 180–182

- **BENREC**: someone or something that benefits from the action expressed by the verb or is the intended recipient of the action described by the verb
 - (12)_{PW} *It gave Ben a reasonable studio and Barbara one near the kitchen, filled with light.*
- **ÆFFECTED**: something (or someone) that is affected by or is the outcome or result of the action described by the verb
 - (15)_{PH} *Once there, Heron had immediately started work on a series of small vertical paintings ...*
- **PREDICATIVE**: identification, equation, characterization or description (which could be seen as subroles of 'PREDICATIVE'):
 - (19)_{PH} *Heron has never been a programmatic artist ...*
- **LOCATIVE: STATIVE**:
 - (16)_{PH} *At Zennor one sees infinite Atlantic ...*
- **LOCATIVE: GOAL**:
 - (20)_{PH} ... *Heron moved beyond the rapid summary strokes and washes of the 'stripe' and 'horizon' paintings towards what he described as a 'true spontaneity' ...*

- **LOCATIVE: SOURCE:**

→ (22)_{PH} ... Heron moved beyond the rapid summary strokes and washes of the 'stripe' and 'horizon' paintings towards what he described as a 'true spontaneity' ...

- **TIME:** time of the action described by the verb:

→ (21)_{PH} Exactly forty years before D.H. Lawrence had moved into Higher Tregerthen, the tiny group of cottages at the bottom of the hill below Eagles Nest ...

- **PURPOSE:**

→ (24)_{PW} In order to realize the subject emotionally and to further his understanding of the composition, Lanyon made use of his practical skills in a number of three-dimensional constructions.

- **TOPIC:**

→ (25)_{PH} Heron had, of course, been thinking and writing about the nature of abstraction since his very first published article in 1945 ...

- **AGENT:** someone that carries out an action:

→ (26)_{PH} Heron had, of course, been thinking and writing about the nature of abstraction since his very first published article in 1945 ...

References

Herbst, Thomas. 2010. *English Linguistics: A Coursebook for Students of English*. Berlin: De Gruyter Mouton.

Quirk, Randolph, Sidney Greenbaum, Geoffrey Leech, and Jan Svartvik. 1985. *A Comprehensive Grammar of the English Language*. Harlow: Longman.